



Improve Farmer Onboarding Experience

by Abrar Sami Khan

 Rural farmers  App + USSD  Agents

Problem Context



Who We Serve

Rural Bangladeshi farmers with **limited digital literacy**, primarily using feature phones or shared smartphones. Many are smallholders earning <\$5/day, with low formal education and high reliance on traditional agricultural practices.



Why Onboarding Matters

Onboarding is the **critical first impression** that determines whether farmers trust and adopt the platform. A failed onboarding means lost lifetime value and wasted acquisition spend in a market where trust is earned slowly.



What "Drop-off" Means

Farmers abandon the onboarding process at key friction points: **registration complexity, OTP failures, confusing interfaces**, or lack of immediate value. Current drop-off rate: **-65%**.

Current State

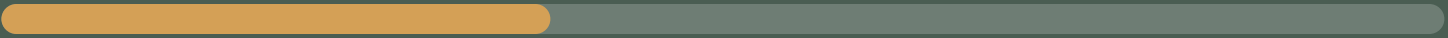
Onboarding Start 100%



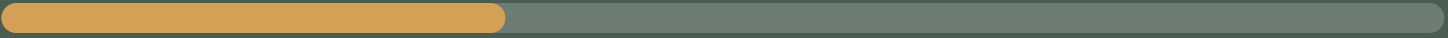
Complete Registration 52%



Verify OTP 38%



First Service Usage 35%



65% of interested farmers never reach first

Key Insight

Every abandoned onboarding represents a farmer who continues to face market exploitation, limited credit access, and climate vulnerability without support.

Key Onboarding Blockers

Five critical barriers identified through field interviews and usability testing



Low Digital Literacy

Most farmers have never used a smartphone app. Unfamiliar UI patterns, navigation gestures, and form fields create immediate confusion and anxiety.

☰ 78% struggle with basic navigation



Language Barriers

English-heavy interfaces exclude Bangla-first speakers. Technical jargon and complex instructions alienate users with limited formal education.

☰ 92% prefer Bangla interface



Low Platform Trust

History of scams and exploitation makes farmers skeptical of unfamiliar digital platforms. "Will this steal my money?" is a common concern.

☰ 64% cite trust as main barrier



Feature Phone Use

60% of target users only have feature phones. App-based onboarding completely excludes this segment, limiting reach and impact.

☰ 60% use only feature phones



Agent & Peer Reliance

Farmers trust recommendations from local agents, cooperatives, and successful peers more than any digital interface or marketing message.

☰ 85% need human assistance

“

Farmers trust people first, then technology.



Human Validation

Farmers need to see someone they trust successfully using the platform before they'll try it themselves. Technology alone cannot build initial trust.



Community Proof

Success stories from neighboring farmers carry more weight than any feature list or promotional content. Peer validation is the strongest conversion driver.



Agent Bridge

Local agents serve as the critical trust bridge, translating technology benefits into familiar language and providing reassurance during the onboarding process.

This insight shapes our entire onboarding strategy

Journey Map with User Persona



Abdur Rahim

Feature Phone User, Low Digital Confidence

important characteristics

42, rice + jute farmer, rural Rajshahi; seasonal cashflow (harvest-based)

Feature phone (USSD), basic reading; uses voice calls more than text

Low trust in "new apps/services"; fears **money loss** and "pressing wrong button"

Relies on **local agent / input dealer / neighbor** for guidance and proof

Typical quote representing the mindset:

Before I give my number or money, I need to be sure this thing is real. If something goes wrong, who will answer me?

most important goals of the profile (in this scenario)

1. Get a **better price** for crops (avoid middlemen cheating on weight/price)

2. Find **safe storage** so he doesn't have to sell immediately after harvest

3. Understand **costs** clearly and avoid any surprise fees / scams



Rahima Begum

Shared Phone, High Responsibility, Low Control

important characteristics

35, homestead vegetable grower + small poultry; rural Khulna

Shared phone (husband/son's smartphone OR feature phone at times); limited privacy/time

Literacy is low-to-medium; confident in farming, not confident in digital steps

Trust built through **women's group / field agent**; needs "permission + reassurance"

Typical quote representing the mindset:

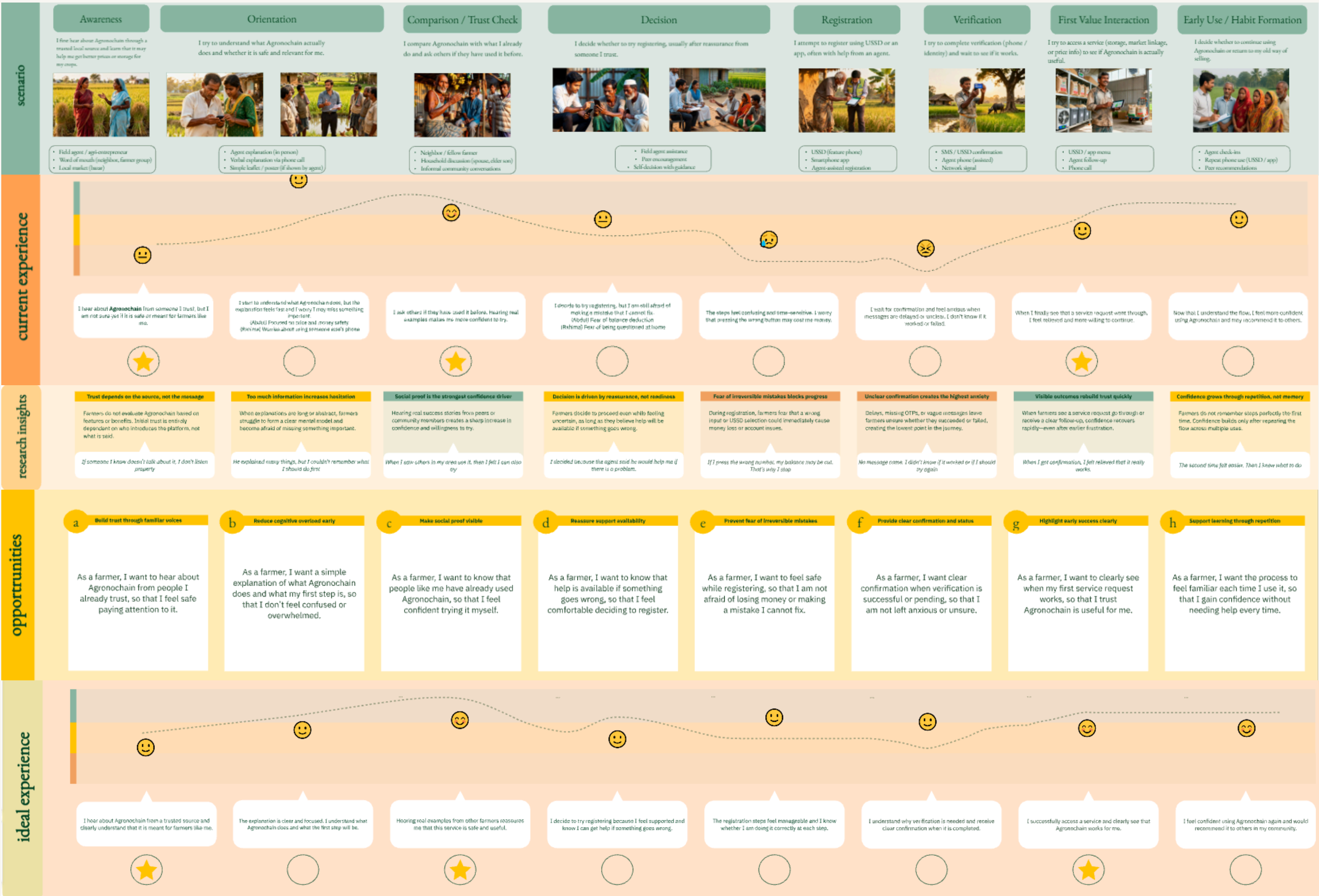
I can work in the field, but these phone steps make me scared. If my husband thinks it's risky, he will stop it.

most important goals of the profile (in this scenario)

1. Access **fair buyers** and avoid being **pressured** into low prices

2. Use **storage/market** services without **family conflict** or **blame** if issues happen

3. Complete any signup with **minimum time**, minimal reading, and clear confirmation



Journey Mapping: Current vs Ideal

Current Journey

- 1

Awareness

Hears about app from agent or flyer

 Curious
- 2

Registration

Complex form with many fields

 Confused

48% DROP
- 3

OTP Verification

SMS code, unclear instructions

 Frustrated

14% DROP
- 4

First Value

Unclear what to do next

 Lost

3% DROP

Ideal Journey(Target conversion rates)

- 1

Awareness

Agent demonstrates success story

 Interested
- 2

Simple Registration

Icon-based, minimal fields, agent helps

 Confident

92% COMPLETION RATE
- 3

Guided OTP

Clear visuals, retry support

 Reassured

85% VERIFICATION RATE
- 4

Immediate Value

Instant market exposure

 Delighted

80% ACTIVATION RATE



Completion Rate

35% → 80%



Time to Value

14 days → 3 days



Farmer NPS

+12 → +35

[Excalibur Board Link](#)

Ideation: Onboarding Improvements



Access & Understanding

1

Icon-Based Bangla UI

Replace text-heavy forms with large, intuitive icons and minimal Bangla text

2

Simplified Language

Use conversational Bangla, avoid technical jargon, keep sentences short

3

Visual Instructions

Step-by-step visual guides with animations showing exactly what to do



Goal: Remove literacy barriers



Trust & Support

4

Agent-Assisted Onboarding

Trained local agents guide farmers through the entire process in-person

5

Peer Success Stories

Showcase video testimonials from trusted local farmers who benefited

6

Community Verification

Allow cooperative leaders to vouch for and verify farmer identities



Goal: Build trust quickly



Confidence & Momentum

7

Progressive Onboarding

Start with minimal info, reveal features gradually as farmer gains confidence

8

Early Value Delivery

Show immediate benefit (weather, prices) before asking for more information

9

Progress Indicators

Clear visual progress bars showing how far they've come and what's next



Goal: Build confidence fast

[Excalibur Board Link](#)

Prioritization: How We Narrowed Down

Prioritization Methods Used

- R

RICE Scoring
Reach × Impact × Confidence ÷ Effort
- M

MoSCoW Method
Must have / Should have / Could have / Won't have
- Value vs. Effort**
2×2 matrix mapping impact against implementation complexity
- Kano Model**
Basic needs vs. Performance vs. Delighters

Selection Criteria

- ✓ Addresses multiple blockers simultaneously
- ✓ Feasible within 3-6 month timeline
- ✓ Works across all channels (App + USSD)
- ✓ Leverages existing agent network
- ✓ Measurable impact on key metrics

🏆 Top 3 Selected Features

- 1

Icon-Based Bangla UI
Rationale: Removes the literacy barrier completely. Large, intuitive icons with minimal text work for all education levels and reduce cognitive load.
- 2

Progressive Onboarding with Early Value
Rationale: Builds confidence through small wins. Farmers see immediate benefit before committing more information, reducing abandonment.
- 3

Agent-Assisted Onboarding
Rationale: Leverages existing trust networks. Agents provide human reassurance, answer questions, and troubleshoot in real-time.

Excalibur Board Link

Solution Overview: Simplified Onboarding Flow



 **Minimal Initial Input**

Only collect essential information upfront (name, phone). Additional profile data gathered progressively over subsequent interactions.

 **Clear Confirmations**

Every action provides immediate visual feedback. Success states are celebrated with animations and clear next-step guidance.

 **NO IRREVERSIBLE Steps**

Farmers can go back and edit information at any point. No decision is final until they explicitly confirm completion.



Total Time to First Value
Under 2 minutes

Lovable published app

Figma published app

Before
8-12 min

→

After
<2 min

Wireframes: Key Screens

Lovable published app

Figma published app

Icon-Based Registration

Screen 1

Simplified OTP Screen

Screen 2

Early Value Delivery

Screen 3

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আপনার তথ্য দিন

নিচের তথ্য পূরণ করুন



এজেন্ট রহমান আপনাকে সাহায্য করবেন
✓ যাচাইকৃত এজেন্ট

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আপনার নাম লিখুন



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পরবর্তী



কোড যাচাই করুন

আপনার মোবাইলে পাঠানো কোডটি লিখুন

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আজকের বাজার দর

সর্বশেষ আপডেট: আজ সকাল ৮টা

✅ abrar, আপনি এখন নিবন্ধিত!
এজেন্ট আপনার সম্পূর্ণ সেটআপ করবেন



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₹32/কেজি



আলু

₹25/কেজি



ভুট্টা

₹28/কেজি



পাট

₹45/কেজি



সরিষা

₹85/কেজি



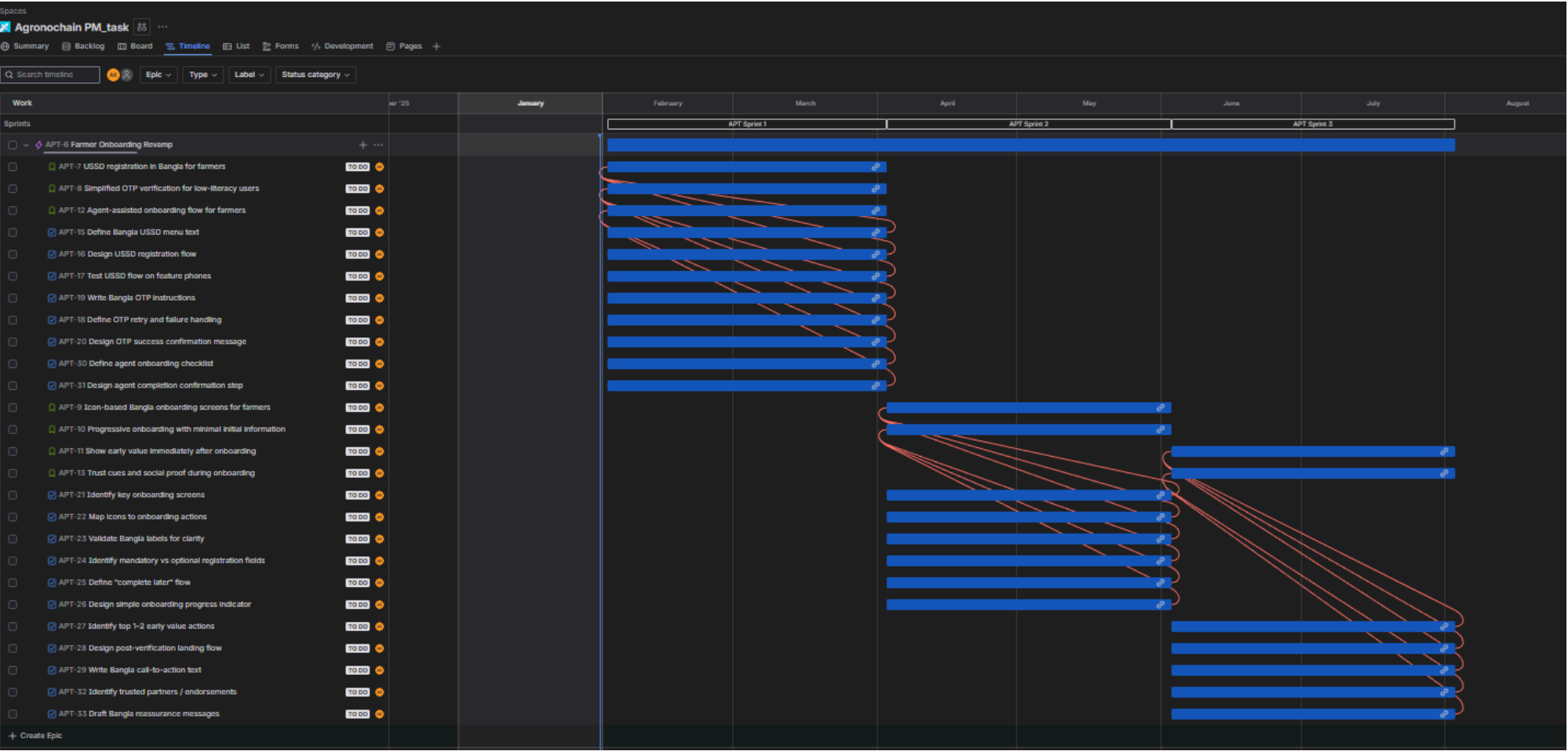
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Jira Backlog & Execution

APT Sprint 2 3 Apr – 2 Jun (8 work items)				
APT-9	Icon-based Bangla onboarding screens for farmers	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Jun 2
APT-10	Progressive onboarding with minimal initial information	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Jun 2
APT-21	Identify key onboarding screens	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-22	Map icons to onboarding actions	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-23	Validate Bangla labels for clarity	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-24	Identify mandatory vs optional registration fields	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-25	Define "complete later" flow	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-26	Design simple onboarding progress indicator	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
Create				

APT Sprint 4 2 Feb – 4 Apr (11 work items)				
APT-7	USSD registration in Bangla for farmers	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Apr 2
APT-8	Simplified OTP verification for low-literacy users	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Apr 2
APT-12	Agent-assisted onboarding flow for farmers	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Apr 2
APT-15	Define Bangla USSD menu text	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-16	Design USSD registration flow	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-17	Test USSD flow on feature phones	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-19	Write Bangla OTP instructions	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-18	Define OTP retry and failure handling	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-20	Design OTP success confirmation message	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-30	Define agent onboarding checklist	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
APT-31	Design agent completion confirmation step	FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	

Sprint 3 3 Jun – 2 Aug (7 work items)				
Show early value immediately after onboarding		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Aug 2
Trust cues and social proof during onboarding		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	Aug 2
Identify top 1-2 early value actions		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
Design post-verification landing flow		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
Write Bangla call-to-action text		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
Identify trusted partners / endorsements		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	
Draft Bangla reassurance messages		FARMER ONBOARDIN...	TO DO	



Jira Backlog Link

Sprint 5

Sprint 5

Success Metrics

Core Metrics

Onboarding Completion Rate

Target: >80%

Current: 35%

Target: 80%

✔ % of farmers who complete full onboarding

OTP Drop-off Rate

Target: <15%

Current: 27%

Target: 15%

✔ % who abandon at OTP verification

Time to First Service Usage

Target: <7 days

14

→

3

days now

days target

✔ Days from signup to first meaningful action

First-Action Completion

Target: >60%

✔ % who complete their first service (price check, warehouse services etc.)

Farmer NPS

Target: ≥ +30

+12

→

+30

current

target

✔ Net Promoter Score from surveyed farmers

Supporting Metrics

Agent-Assisted Onboarding Success

% of farmers successfully onboarded with agent help vs. self-serve

Cost Per Activated Farmer

Total onboarding cost divided by successfully activated farmers

Agent Dependency Over Time

Track if farmers become more self-sufficient after initial onboarding

Phased Roadmap: 3-6 Month Timeline

1 Access & Trust Month 1-2

Key Deliverables

- ✓ Icon-based Bangla UI design system
- ✓ Simplified registration flow (2 fields)
- ✓ USSD onboarding MVP

Success Criteria

- Registration completion: 55% → 75%
- Agent-assisted success: 60% → 80%

2 Guided Onboarding Month 3-4

Key Deliverables

- ✓ Progressive step-by-step wizard
- ✓ Visual progress indicators
- ✓ Simplified OTP with auto-detect
- ✓ Error recovery flows

Success Criteria

- OTP drop-off: 20% → <15%
- Completion rate: 70% → 80%

3 Activation & Retention Month 5-6

Key Deliverables

- ✓ Early value dashboard (warehouses, prices)
- ✓ Peer success story videos
- ✓ Self-service feature expansion
- ✓ Agent performance dashboard and onboarding tools

Success Criteria

- Time to first value: 7 days → 3 days
- First-action completion: 40% → 60%

Key Milestones & Dependencies



Week 2

Icon library approved



Week 4

Agent training complete



Week 8

MVP launch (500 farmers)



Week 12

Full rollout (5,000 farmers)